



AT YOUR SERVICE

Renana Jhabvala

55, Social Worker

For Renana Jhabvala life revolves around her work. From whirlwind meetings with cloth vendors and agarbatti sellers to travelling across rural areas to figure out how one can best provide financial freedom to millions of unprivileged women in India, it's all in a day's work for the daughter of writer Ruth Pravar Jhabvala. As part of the Self-Employed Women's Association (SEWA), Jhabvala has dedicated 30 years to the organisation. "Here at SEWA we firmly believe in the hidden energy inside every woman." Jhabvala, a product of Yale University, came back to India and remembers her first meeting when she was 25, with SEWA founder Ela Bhatt in 1977. She was converted then and there. She is now trying to establish all-women market zones to give displaced women vendors a permanent work place. Jhabvala revels in the passionate responses she gets from the women members of the organisation, "A look at them and one feels that a new world has opened for them. And we respond by giving them the means of exploring themselves."

FIRST INVESTMENT My fixed deposits at the SEWA bank.

WORST DECISION AND THE LESSON LEARNT It would perhaps be some of the SEWA projects that failed. An instance would be the re-afforestation project in Gujarat in the late 1980s. It failed miserably. It taught me that achievements matter as much as values, especially in business like ours, where the vision is often grand and requires meticulous implementation.

BEST ADVICE I EVER GOT AND FROM WHOM Has to be from Ela Bhatt about my work. She always said I must always listen to people around me and seek advice from the women we work with, even though they may have no experience.

**USE
THIS
TIP**

"SAVINGS IS THE BIGGEST SECURITY BLANKET A WOMAN CAN HAVE. IT LENDS AN IMMENSE SENSE OF SELF-CONFIDENCE TOO."